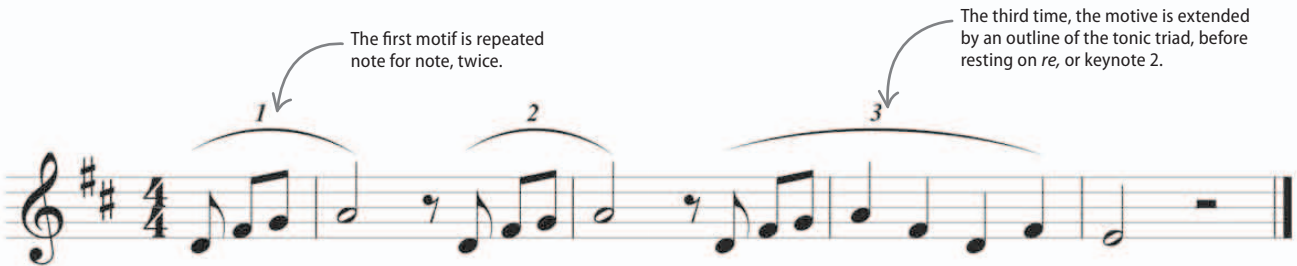


Repetition

Melodies with some repetition, or a slightly varied reuse of material, sound cohesive and satisfying. Often, as in the first phrase of “When the Saints Go Marching In,” a motif (short pattern) will repeat three times. The first two repetitions are identical. The third begins the same, but ends with a more elaborate addition, ornamentation, or closing statement.

▽ “When the Saints Go Marching In”

The origins of this American gospel hymn are unknown, but it is now a popular jazz tune, a rallying tune for many sports teams, and a religious anthem.



Rhythm

Each subsection of this folk-song melody uses an identical rhythm, unifying the entire tune. Note the “Rule of Three” at work here—the triplet motif is used three times in a row, but the melody steps down, pitch by pitch, to the keynote, to emphasize the return to *do*, or scale degree 1.

▽ “Sally Go Round the Sun”

This is an African-American folk tune from the Seal Islands, off the coast of South Carolina.



LOOKING CLOSER

Tips for analyzing melodies

Ask yourself the following questions about melodic elements to determine if and how they are relevant to understanding the function of the melody.

What is the first note of each phrase? What is the last note?

What is the last note of the melody? How does the last measure function to create a feeling of finality?

Identify notes in terms of scale degrees. Look particularly for tones that are stable (scale degrees 1, 3, 5), and those that need to move to resolve (2, 7).

How many phrases are there? Are any phrases the same? How do they differ?

What rhythmic and melodic patterns repeat themselves?

What sections of the melody are notably different? How is the contrast made between same and different?

Does the melody generally flow between notes close to each other, or are the tones drastically different?

If text is present, what elements of the melody seem to interact purposely with the lyrics? Does the melodic structure highlight portions of the tune?